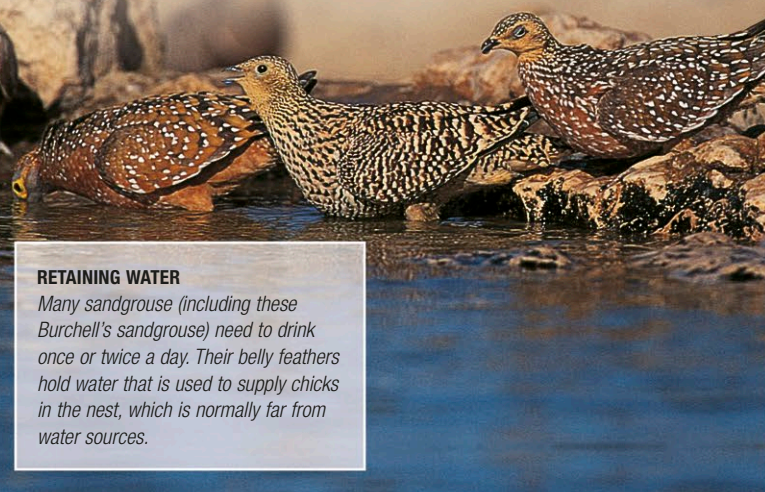


Sandgrouse

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Pteroclidiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Pteroclididae)
SPECIES	16

These intricately patterned birds live in arid areas of Africa and Asia. They spend most of their time on the ground, where they are well camouflaged by their brown or gray, spotted or barred plumage. Sandgrouse resemble both grouse and pigeons. Like grouse, they have a small head, a squat body, and feathers on their legs, yet when they take to the air, they fly strongly on long, pointed wings, with fast, steady wingbeats like those of pigeons. Their thick neck and short legs are also pigeonlike.



RETAINING WATER

Many sandgrouse (including these Burchell's sandgrouse) need to drink once or twice a day. Their belly feathers hold water that is used to supply chicks in the nest, which is normally far from water sources.

Pterocles coronatus

Crowned sandgrouse



Location N. Africa, W. to S. Asia

Length 10½–12 in (27–30 cm)

Weight 9–11 oz (250–300 g)

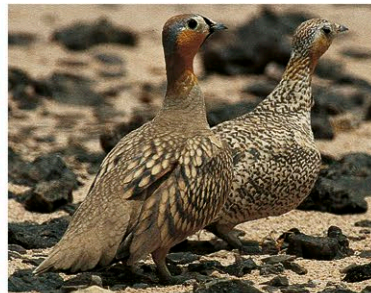
Plumage Sexes differ

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Least concern



This well-camouflaged bird lives in some of the most extreme desert areas, helped by its low energy and water requirements, its ability to tolerate air temperatures exceeding 122° F (50° C) for several hours, and its tolerance of water with a high salt content. The male has a sandy-orange crown and a black mask at the base of his bill, while the female is grayer and more barred.



Pterocles namaqua

Namaqua sandgrouse



Location Southern Africa

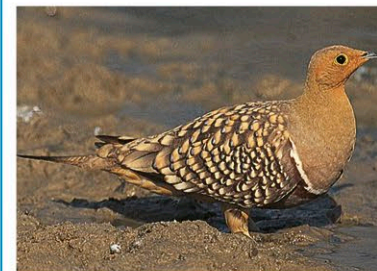
Length 11 in (28 cm)

Weight 6–7 oz (175–200 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Least concern



The Namaqua sandgrouse shares many desert-specific adaptations with the crowned sandgrouse (see left): it needs little food or water, and its thick plumage insulates it from high and low temperatures. A pale brown head, white breastband, and mottled brown wings provide excellent camouflage against the stony ground and sand. This bird travels to areas that have received good rainfall in search of seeds, which are its sole source of food.

Pigeons

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Columbiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Columbidae)
SPECIES	342

The familiar pigeons seen in cities and on arable farms throughout the world are only a small part of a diverse group. Tropical forests are home to an immense variety of species, many of them brilliantly colored, living on the ground or in trees. The larger kinds are generally known

as pigeons and the smaller ones as doves. Adult pigeons and doves produce nutritious “crop-milk,” which they feed to their young.

Anatomy

Pigeons and doves are plump, full-breasted birds with a small head and bill; the head bobs as the bird walks, to keep it in a constant position relative to the body. These birds are strong fliers, their broad wings driven by powerful breast muscles that enable them to travel long distances at considerable speed. The plumage is thick and soft, although most species have a patch of bare skin around each eye.



IRIDESCENT FEATHERS



BRIGHT COLORATION

PLUMAGE

Many tropical pigeons and doves, such as the wompoo fruit dove (left) have bright and varied plumage. Although other species (such as the stock dove, far left) are less strikingly colored, they have small iridescent patches.

Feeding

Pigeons and doves eat mainly plant material. They can be broadly divided into 2 groups: seed-eaters and fruit-eaters. All have a specially adapted gut, with a well-developed crop and a strong, muscular gizzard; the latter is used for grinding food, often aided by ingested grit or stones. Fruit-eaters, taking more easily digestible food, have shorter guts than seed-eaters.



ROOSTING

Pigeons and doves often roost communally, either in spaced out groups (like these crested pigeons), or huddled together. When disturbed, several roosting birds will take off with sudden wingbeats, a shock tactic designed to alarm a predator.



FEEDING YOUNG

These young turtle doves are being fed on “milk” secreted by their mother's crop. Crop-milk is produced by both sexes and is rich in proteins and fats.